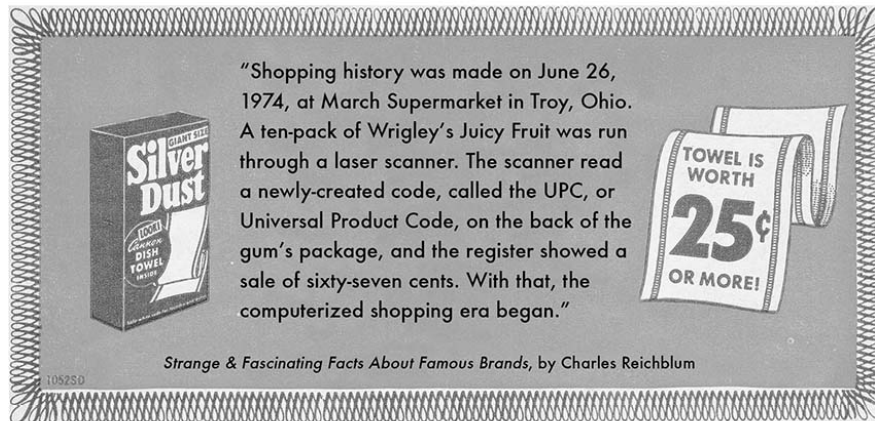




Manufacturers were preparing to drop the UPC-A bar code on coupons and use only the GS1 Data Bar by January 2011. However, the transition for retailers who needed to update point of sale software and scanners resulted in a more gradual change with the extended deadline of summer 2011 for a complete elimination of the old code. The new codes included an expiration date, assuring coupons aren't used after the set date. Better yet, the new data bar completely eliminated one of the most flagrant abuses of coupons: that of using a coupon on a related item that it isn't specified for, such as a "\$10 tooth-whitening" coupon on a package of diapers made by the same manufacturer.

Never considered the possibility that a consumer would blatantly and routinely do such a thing? I hadn't either, until I unearthed forum archives on the website Dealideal.com that contained incriminating information. Postings dated before 2010 reflected a grave concern over the future update of the barcodes. Apparently, before the anticipated changes, members had been "reading" coupon bar codes so they could figure out which ones would scan for products they weren't designated for. Newbies to the site